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Individuality, Power, and Conformity

How Group Communication Shaped the Stanford Prison Experiment



Dr. Phillip Zimbardo

In August of 1971, Dr. Phillip Zimbardo began an infamous psychology experiment in the basement of Jordan Hall, part of Stanford University, where he taught. The experiment compensated (about $100 a day in today's money) a set of 24 young men, which subsequently were split into two groups: Prisoners and Guards. These two groups were placed in a mock-prison without windows or clocks. Each Prisoner was stripped of their clothes and given sacks embroidered with numbers to signify a new identity. Each Guard was given a new uniform, baton, and sunglasses. In addition to the Prisoners and Guards, a group of experimental Directors oversaw the live footage and were to intervene if relations between Prisoners and Guards became too hostile. Originally meant to last two weeks, the Stanford Prison Experiment lasted only 6 days as tensions escalated, violence ensued, and some Prisoners experienced massive psychological breakdowns.

In 2015, The Stanford Prison Experiment was adapted to a Hollywood Docudrama film of the same name, directed by Kyle Alvarez. This film references the original footage shot in 1971 to replicate many scenes within the picture, with uneasy realism.

Although the docudrama takes a few liberties, as most historical dramas do, Dr. Zimbarado, as well as participants in the experiment, have come forth to endorse the film. The following paper will explore the expressions of power and conformity through three parties in the prison experiment: Prisoners, Guards, and Directors, based on the events of the 2015 adaptation.



Kyle Patrick Alvarez plays Dr. Philip Zimbardo in the 2015 film, “The Stanford Prison Experiment”.

Power

Richmond, et al. (1980 p. 38) addresses five ‘bases’ of power which individuals draw from in order to influence others. These five bases are: (1) *legitimate* power (appointed, elected, entrusted), (2) *referent* power (social or physical attraction), (3) *expert* power (having specialized knowledge or information), (4) *reward* power (a person’s ability to reward others), and (5) *coercive* power (a person’s ability to punish others). Beebe and Masterson (2015 p. 116) define power as, “involv[ing] the ability of one person to control or influence some other person or decision.” The Stanford Prison Experiment is rich with examples of these forms of power being used over the course of the 6 days of the experiment.

One of the main objectives of the Stanford Prison Experiment was to monitor the effects of deindividuation and dehumanization on seemingly sane, healthy

individuals. By nature, these goals seek to remove all forms of power from the Prisoners in this study. It appears, however, throughout the 6 days of the experiment, as Prisoner morale decreases and psychosis sets in, some individuals, yet still, attempt to grasp for power. For example, early on, Prisoner #8612 tries to solidify bonds with fellow Prisoners to plan an escape and develop plans to rescue one another upon exit (*referent* and *reward*). The same Prisoner begs to see a doctor in a psychotic breakdown, screaming that he was, "burning up inside" and should be allowed to leave because of his contract ("*You have no right to fuck with my head!*") (*legitimate*). The Prisoner's in Cell 1 attempt to blockade their cell door on day 2, as a form of protection and disobedience (*coercive*). At one point, a Prisoner attacks a guard out of frustration (*coercive*). Although these moments occur in spurts, the power of the Prisoners is minimal and almost always extinguished by Guard actions.



The Guards, from their first moment, are bestowed with *legitimate* power since they have been entrusted with running the prison itself. They utilize *reward* and *coercive* power through this *legitimate* lens for their own sadistic pleasure and lustful need for control. It begins with requests for Prisoners to do seemingly silly things such as stripping naked, spreading their legs wider for no apparent reason, doing push-ups or jumping jacks and then turns into more terrifying requests such as being asked to

act like Frankenstein and verbalize their love for one another, verbally condemn a fellow Prisoner (*"Prisoner #819 did a bad thing!"*), and being asked to, "Hump your female camels!" in an act of forced sexual assault. Additionally, the Guards repeatedly use sexist, gendered verbal abuse throughout the experiment through statements including, "Sing like a little girl," "Do real man push-ups," "Don't disappoint your mamma," and "It's your wife's nature to be overprotective." The Guards restrict basic necessities from their Prisoners including medications, glasses, and medical care. These are all, ultimately, examples of *coercive* power. At first, Prisoners are afraid what the Guards are actually capable of, which comes with its own type of fear. Later, after Guards physically assault Prisoners with their batons, hands (and other tools including fire extinguishers), Prisoners are coerced into submission out of fear of being assaulted.

The role of the Directors of the experiment cannot be understated. Throughout the experiment, the Directors (particularly Dr. Zimbarado) subvert the legitimacy of the written contracts and rights of the participants in his study (*legitimate*), in an effort to coerce their participants into complying to the unsafe conditions of the mock prison (*coercive*). In a few instances, the Directors conform *to* the wishes/power of the Prisoners and set them free, but only if knowing they wouldn't make a fuss out of the ordeal and involve lawyers (*reward*). As psychologists, the Directors maintain their *expert* power to shut down seemingly false accusations about the living conditions of the Prisoners and try to show there is a bigger picture to the experiment that these laymen can comprehend.

Many of the forms of power enact upon each other in these three groups is a reaction to other powers being placed upon them. When a Prisoner attempts to enact his *legitimate* power, a Guard enacts his *coercive* power, and a Director supports these coercive acts with his *expert, legitimate,* and *reward* powers. In other words, power, throughout this experiment, is a reaction to power. Control being placed upon an individual spur the individual to try to place control on another.



Conformity

Reitan and Shaw (1964 p. 45–51) identify five factors that influence conformity in groups: (1) *individual characteristics of the group members,* (2) *clarity of the norm and the certainty of punishment for breaking it*, (3) *the number of people who have already conformed to the norm*, (4) *the quality of the interpersonal relationships that have developed in the group*, and (5) *the sense of a group identification that members have developed.* For the purposes of this section, these factors will be addressed as (1) *characteristics of group*, (2) *expectations and punishment,* (3) *number of conformists*, (4) *interpersonal relationships*, and (5) *group identity*. In the context of the Stanford Prison Experiment, these factors seek to explain how and why Prisoners, Guards, and Directors each conformed to a certain script.

Through the 6 day experiment, many Prisoners came to terms with the fact that their power was very limited. Most opportunities of power were promptly shut down by other forms of power, namely *coercive* power. To protect themselves, Prisoners had to conform to their role as nameless, powerless Prisoners (*expectations and punishment*, *group identity*). Earlier in the experiment, a select few Prisoners

attempted to break the mold of conformity, individualizing themselves by ripping apart their clothes, taking off their numbers and hats. They seem to acknowledge that there is a direct correlation between individuality and potential of power and being powered upon. As time progressed, Prisoner's realize the limits of their power to change their conditions. As evidenced in the scene condemning Prisoner #819 (*"Prisoner #819 did a bad thing!"*), Prisoners eventually solidify their group identity as conformity increases and relationships are formed (*group identity, characteristics of the group, number of conformists, interpersonal relationships*). Conformity, in theory, begins to legitimize their power to protect themselves. Ultimately, they are still regularly abused until the very climax where Dr. Zimbarado ends the experiment when the Guards force the Prisoners into sexual violence.



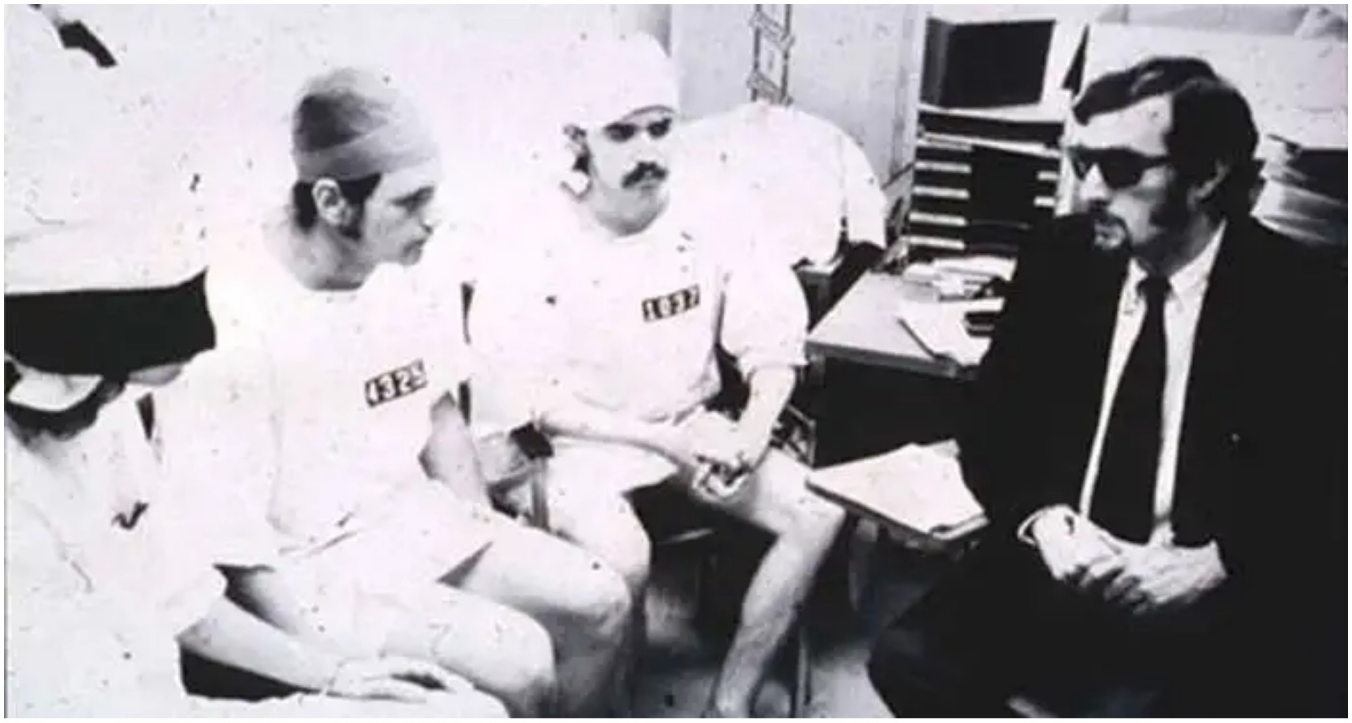
In an interview with Guard, Dave Eshelman, he expressed shocked, "No one questioned my authority at all. It really shocked me." Throughout the experiment, Eshelman developed a persona (John Wayne) which rose to an implied leadership position amongst the guards. He goes on in his interview to discuss how no one truly fought his policies within the mock prison; they just conformed to what he said no matter the abuse (*expectations and punishment, interpersonal conflict*). This goes, too, for the other Guards. No one, throughout the experiment, ever questioned the ethics or moral implications of what they were doing as Guards. The sense of group

identity was too strong. The ability to control was unquestioned. From a practical standpoint, putting the Guards in the same uniform, with the same sunglasses, and same batons created a "unified single authority" (Alvarez 2015) which fed into these roles.

The greatest division on conformity, at least in the film, is expressed by the team of Directors. Shaw (1964) writes, "More intelligent persons are less likely to conform than less intelligent persons." Get a handful of ambitious, extremely bright psychologists, advocates, and scholars into a room and different opinions will ensue (*characteristics of group*). Some Directors see the completion of the experiment as the ultimate goal (the findings are important and have Post-Positivist implications). Some Directors use a Critical Approach and see this experiment as having the ability to reshape the modern prison structure and must be dealt with care. Some Directors want to see how far the Prisoners and Guards will go in their exercises of conformity and power (to this, I, the author, become part of the issue).

Conclusion

There are so many dimensions of power and conformity that could not be covered in such a short paper. There is a direct correlation between an individuals ability to exert power, the power exerted upon them, and the act of conforming in relation to being acted upon. The Stanford Prison Experiment reviews our nature, as humans, to assume identities that empower or victimize ourselves. Theoretical power becomes legitimate power. Legitimate power becomes a lens through which coercive and reward power can be used to manipulate and conform groups of individuals. Individuality combats the detrimental effects of power gone awry but is only valid once it's been acknowledged. The individual identity rests just as much in the hands of others as it does oneself. It's to be known and accepted. This study teaches essential lessons about the type of power we are capable of exerting when given the opportunity. It also shows us the kind of conformity we are capable of falling into when coerced to. These implications can be applied to areas including simple team activities, political divides, cultish subjection, illegal drug rings, and sex trafficking. It hints as to why we respond to these tense situations in the way we do.



Psychology Identity Mental Health Communication Crime

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